and the Aga Khan who had an old connection with IFC made his own inquiries about the bona fides of Parekh and HDFC. The Aga Khan also read IFC's first appraisal report on HDFC and was impressed. Nasser says that at the time only he and his father were backing the project. The Ismaili Khoja leadership in India had advised the Aga Khan against any involvement in HDFC. 'My father and I were the only people who advised him to participate in the project in some way. All others were against it.'[5]

In January 1978, the Aga Khan visited Bombay and a meeting was fixed with Parekh. The Aga Khan took a very keen interest in the project and asked Parekh: 'What do you want me to do for you?' Parekh asked the Aga Khan for the support of his community in the HDFC share issue since it was going to be difficult to get the public to invest in what many considered an 'experiment'. Imagine Parekh's surprise when the Aga Khan said: 'Mr Parekh what would you think of making me the third promoter on an equal basis with the first two?' Nasser and his father were equally surprised since they knew that the Aga Khan had been advised against investing in HDFC.[6] A delighted Parekh was only too pleased to accept. Five years later at a speech at a dinner in honour of the Aga Khan, Parekh observed: 'I had gone to seek his blessings; but I got even more.'[7] He had now raised 15 percent of the new company's equity. Parekh then began approaching big business houses for help. His first port of call was J.R.D. Tata. After closely examining the project, J.R.D. agreed to contribute ₹50 lakhs of capital through various companies in the Tata group. Thereafter, it took Parekh almost a year to mobilize the needed capital. After much persuasion, some banks and insurance companies promised token support.

Nasser who was with HDFC for nearly two decades became the Executive Director, and is still on the board of HDFC. He recollects his years at HDFC and his interaction with Parekh with obvious affection. 'I seldom admire people but he is one man I greatly admire. I still miss him. He was an amazing human being. He had his heart in the right place. He combined simplicity of values with a very active mind. And he was very persistent and never gave up.'[8] Nasser recalls with pleasure the many 'dabba lunches' he shared with Parekh. The two discussed a variety of topics and this was when Parekh, who was known to enjoy a cigar, was at his most relaxed.